Hindus were specifically targeted in slogans, songs and speeches. Bhindranwale was the main attraction at the meeting, and Longowal appeared to play second fiddle to him. [9]

It would be interesting to note here that many in Amritsar were aware that R.L. Bhatia, president of the Punjab State Congress party and the local Member of Parliament for whom Bhindranwale had canvassed during the 1980 elections, continued to maintain contact with Bhindranwale through Amrik Singh till as late as May 1984. [10] It is obvious that Bhatia was maintaining that connection on behalf of the 1 Akbar Road group. Though Amrik Singh's release at this point was described as a mistake, it could also have been the result of a move by the 1 Akbar Road Group to introduce a more sinister dimension to the already chaotic situation. The proceedings of the AISSF conference Amrik Singh organized would bear this out.

Soon after this, friction between Longowal and Bhindranwale surfaced. The two started spending most of their time in their respective rooms in Guru Nanak Niwas. The activities of Bhindranwale's 'killer squad' also gained momentum. At least five bodies were found in the sewers close to Guru Nanak Niwas in August and September 1983. During this period, unverified stories of Bhindranwale's 'hit list' began circulating. The list reportedly included names of police officers and government officials, Hindus as well as Sikhs, with whom Bhindranwale had scores to settle.

A police officer, Bichhu Ram, who had forcibly trimmed the beard of a Sikh, was killed within six months of the incident. Bhindranwale and his men also started sending threatening letters to newspaper editors and journalists, including Khushwant Singh and Prem Bhatia, the editor of the Chandigarh-based daily, the *Tribune* . Bhindranwale's interpreter at the time is reported to have said, 'No one can refuse Santji's orders.' [11]

Communal discord

Following inflammatory anti-Hindu speeches at the AISSF meeting at the Golden Temple on 28 September 1983, some Sikhs fired upon a group of Hindu morning walkers at Jagraon, a small town near